that Meenakshi barely went to school. Married at the age of twelve to a man nearly seventeen years older, she was soon the mother of two sons. She had not even begun to comprehend the import of her husband's politics when she became the wife of a political convict. Meenakshi's letters make for poignant reading as she faced unprecedented adversities.

A week after meeting VOC in jail, on 29 January 1912, Meenakshi wrote to G. Subramania Iyer. As the liquidation process unfolded, VOC's mind, it would appear, was focused on the interests of the many who had invested in the company mostly at his behest and exhortation. Her husband, Meenakshi wrote, was more than ever determined to overcome all hardships and resume his efforts to rejuvenate 'our nation's commerce and industry' and 're-establish our ancient glory in this field'. VOC, she said, had thought of ways to redeem the losses of all the investors, in addition to making good the interest on capital lost.[70] A month later, writing to two of the earliest promoters of the company, and VOC's trusted friends, A.M.M. Arunachalam Pillai and S.S.V. Krishna Pillai, Meenakshi said her husband had inquired about the fate of the Swadeshi company.[71] These were not sentiments that he expressed through his wife alone. In three quatrains that VOC wrote to C. Vijayaraghavachari at this time, he first asked him to convey his respects to all those who contributed to the shipping company: once he was released and good days were back, he promised, he would make good their losses. An upright man, VOC felt that he had a moral responsibility for the losses suffered by the investors.

Even as he was reassuring well-wishers and investors of the company, on 1 May 1912, a bombshell dropped on VOC's prison cell. The acting *sheristadar* of the court of the district judge, Tirunelveli, in an interlocutory application of the original petition filed by the official liquidator, issued a notice on 19 April 1912. It demanded that VOC remit Rs 1903-0-6 under Section 149 of the Indian Companies Act. VOC was to appear in court either in person or by pleader on 2 May 1912. VOC had only a day to respond to the notice.[72]

VOC was shocked, to say the least. On receiving the court notice he wrote five quatrains that captures his mood. Steeling himself, he wrote in